Knife Basics One-Pager

Grip it, cut it, keep it sharp — safer prep in one page

THE GRIP

- **Pinch grip**: curl three fingers around the *blade* right where handle meets blade; thumb and index finger hold the flat sides.
- **Guide hand**: your other hand holds the food — make a "claw" with knuckles forward and fingertips tucked back behind them. The blade rests lightly against the knuckles.
- **Board grip**: damp towel or paper towel under the cutting board so it cannot slide. One second, saves trips to the ER.
- **Visibility rule**: if you can't see your fingertips past your knuckles, curl them more.

THE ROCKING MOTION (FOR A CHEF'S KNIFE)

- Let the **tip rest on the board** while you rock the heel of the blade down and forward — smooth lurching arc, like a rocking chair.
- Work in **a rhythm, not force:** sharp knives need pressure, dull ones need muscle — and they are the scary ones.
- Move food with the **flat side of the blade** or a scraper — never with an open edge.

CUTS YOU'LL ACTUALLY USE

CUT	SIZE	USE IT FOR
Dice	~¼–½ inch cubes	Soups, stews, hashes
Chop (rough)	Irregular, casual	Parsley, onions for slow braises — perfectly fine to NOT be perfect
Mince	Very fine	Garlic, ginger, herbs to spread evenly in sauces
Slice	Thin even pieces	Citrus, onions, mushrooms
Julienne (optional)	Matchsticks	Slaws, stir-fries. Nice to have, not needed.

A FAST ONION DEMO (MIND THE CLAW)

1. Halve root-to-tip; peel both halves.
2. Set flat side down on board (this is the safe no-roll step people forget).
3. Horizontal cuts toward (but not through) the root.
4. Vertical slices root-to-tip; then cross for dice.
5. Sweep into a bowl or skillet — done. Wash hands and board to clear the onion smell.

SHARPNESS & CARE

TOPIC	WHAT TO DO
Test sharpness	It should glide through tomato skin without pressing. If it slides, hone first.
Hone	5 strokes each side on a honing steel, weekly. Straightens the edge between sharpening.
Sharpen	Whetstone or pull-through sharpener, 2–3 times a year. A $2 sharpener that works beats an expensive dull one.
Wash & dry	Hand wash, towel-dry immediately. Never goes into the sink of soapy water (blind cuts) and never the dishwasher.
Store	Magnetic strip, block, or blade guard. The drawer-of-loose-blades is how cuts happen.
Fall rule	**Never** try to catch a falling knife. Step back, let it land, then pick it up by the handle.

> **Starter kit** (~$40): one 8-inch chef's knife (a solid mid-range brand beats a block set), one paring knife, one honing steel, one cutting board. Skip the 14-piece kit — two sharp knives cook anything.